

that might be drawn from the affinities I have thus sketched. They lead us, I think, to realise more effectively the consequences of the fact that Media is the Western limit of Iranian language in ancient times. Except for the perplexing Indian (or Aryan) gods at Boghaz-keui and the assumed Iranian names of Mitanni chiefs, near the middle of the second millennium, we have no sign of Aryan language west of the forty-second meridian, to which limit the Medes and the Karduchi (Kurds) represent the Iranian branch.¹ Iranian speech manifestly claims more and more of the ground as we go east. It is, therefore, at least natural to suggest that Media was the resisting medium in which the Iranian migration westward was arrested, only a proportion of the population being affected by the language invasion from Persia. The net result is that linguistic probabilities tend to reinforce the inference, drawn above on stronger grounds, that the Magi were part of the indigenous population of Media. They may have been sooner or later assimilated to the Persians in speech, but in racial characteristics, and in customs preserved by them from a remote antiquity as a sacred tribe, they owe nothing to either Aryans or Semites, and are purely aboriginal.

¹ Can the Kurds represent a swarm of nomads that left the main stream and struck southwards before reaching the north of the Caspian? The Sarmatae, just the other side of the Caucasus, and the Ossetes who still hold the Caucasus region, mark this path of Iranian migration. We could account for the Iranian chiefs of the Mitanni in this way. As to Boghaz-keui, we must be content to wait for more information, and hold ourselves prepared to tear up some pet theories, if necessary, when it comes. On the Iranian character of Mitanni names I should be sorry to dogmatise. Have we really evidence enough? (Compare p. 423 n.².)